

change will affect livelihood assets, agriculture and food production, access to water and natural resources. The increased frequency and intensity of disasters that accompany climate change will add to displacement, migration and social conflicts. There will be an increase in salinity, water logging, cyclones and sea level rise in the coastal zones of Bangladesh. The north-central, east and central floodplains are already affected by frequent and prolonged flooding, higher depth, expansion and erosion. The northwest drought-prone area is affected by scarcity of water, draw-down of ground water, low rainfall, high temperatures, more heat waves and storms.

Ultimately, the people of Bangladesh will face different types of risk, which might be summarized as follows. Rising sea level will decrease 17% of total land and 13% of cultivated land, affecting 35 million people in 19 coastal districts. Frequency of cyclones will increase. Damage to the country's infrastructure will be more apparent. Sea level rise and intrusion of sea water into the coastal belt will increase the salinity of the soil, which will also likely reduce fresh water by 20%. Production loss will be seen in food

grain. Production of Boro rice (a dry season crop) will decline 3% by 2030 and 5% by 2050. Floods will be more frequent. There will be



Ganges River Delta, Bangladesh. Photo courtesy NASA, via Wikimedia Commons

expanded river erosion. The health sector will be burdened beyond endurable limits. There will be increasing food insecurity.

State initiatives for poverty reduction and achieving goals for the millennium are now challenged. The impact of climate change is clear: it increases people's vulnerability to poverty and social deprivation. Populations of indigenous people, whose rights are poorly protected, are likely to be the least equipped to adapt to climate change effects. The human costs of climate change include direct threats to internationally accepted human rights:

rights to life, food, health, a place to live, and work.



Climate change adds to existing challenges for indigenous peoples, including political and economic marginalization, and land and resource encroachments. Although most major international human rights treaties contain provisions concerned with the environment, universal recognition and protection of environmental or ecological rights continue to be significant challenges for international human rights law. The potential threat of climate change to the very existence of indigenous peoples is amplified when combined with various legal and institutional barriers, including conservation and wildlife management regimes, resource-use quota systems, and trade barriers that limit the ability of indigenous populations (including those in Bangladesh) to cope with and adapt to climate change.

Increasingly anthropologists are encountering the local effects of climate change and engaging with related social, cultural, economic and political issues on a broader level. They are becoming critical of the adaptive capacity and resilience of developing countries, and question whether currently available coping mechanisms are sufficient. Although their research is productive in addressing the issues at hand, this may unfortunately be evidence that the global discourse has turned to adaptation as a priority for research and policy, giving less importance to the climate change mitigation.

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Redefining the Gap between Theory and Practice

Should Anthropologists Try to Change the World?

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Anthropology of education is a hybrid field. In one respect it is simply cultural or linguistic anthropology that explores educational institutions and processes. Such research illuminates theoretical and empirical issues of concern to the discipline as a whole (eg, Levinson, "Resituating the Place of Educational Discourse in Anthropology," *American Anthropologist* 101; Wortham, "Linguistic Anthropology of Education," *Annual Review of Anthropology* 37). Many anthropologists of education also try to improve educational practice. The subfield thus raises a normative question: should anthropology try to change the world, and if so how?

In order to address this question we must move beyond the typical picture of how theory

(or academic research) and practice relate. We must first distinguish two senses of "practice." Many of the tools that people use to accomplish cognitive work come from sociohistorically located practices (Cole, 1996, *Cultural Psychology*). This is the first sense of "practice," which I will refer to as "activity." An emphasis on "activity" is part of the sociocen-

of knowledge to explore academic work that does not involve practice in the second sense, as sociologists of science do (Knorr-Cetina, 1999, *Epistemic Cultures*). One could also use a decontextualized, non-activity-based sense of knowledge to explore how academic knowledge gets translated into practice in the second sense. This latter approach generates a "gap"

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tric turn away from decontextualized, individual-centered conceptions of knowledge and toward conceptions of knowledge as embedded in practice. Second, "practice" refers to a set of activities in which people like teachers and social service providers try to change the world. "Activity" and "practice" are orthogonal. One could use an activity-based conception

between theory and practice, as if decontextualized knowledge must cross an in-kind gap in order to influence practice.

On the sociocentric account of knowledge that I would defend, however, knowledge is always embedded in activities. There is no qual-

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itative gap to be crossed when we apply knowledge to practice. Apparently decontextualized knowledge is embedded in social contexts and political struggles just as much as practical activities are, and practitioners develop and use both more and less decontextualized knowledge. This does not make the theory-practice gap disappear, however. There is a gap, but one between different domains of activity. Researchers and practitioners have different “repertoires of practice,” sets of beliefs, habits and capacities. Academic researchers build conceptual arguments and analyze data, while educational practitioners (for example) guide young people toward more competent participation in relevant activities. Repertoires are heterogeneous within and between groups. No skill or idea is shared by all academics or practitioners, and the repertoires of academics and practitioners overlap. But the central tendencies nonetheless differ. Overcoming the theory-

practice gap thus involves the *practical* task of moving beliefs, habits and capacities across domains. We can cross the gap, for instance, by using resources that have been developed in more decontextualized activities—like the conceptualization, observation and description typically engaged in by anthropologists—to help practitioners intervene in the world.

Returning to the question of whether anthropology should try to change the world, part of my answer is clear. Anthropologists cannot help but change the world. All anthropological research involves materially and socially-embedded activities. Most anthropologists also use ideas and skills from their academic work at least occasionally as they engage with practice as commentators, parents, community members or activists (Marcus, 1999, *Critical Anthropology Now*). Because of its explicit connections with practice, the anthropology of education reminds us of our opportunities to influence practice. This need not involve the large-scale commitment one imagines would be required to overcome a qualitative gap. It can be more improvisational and everyday, taking advantage of opportunities to share academic

beliefs, habits and capacities with practitioners. While gathering data recently, for instance, I discovered that my familiarity with ethnographic interviewing—primarily the injunction to listen for others’ categories and not impose my own—could serve as a useful model for teacher conferences with immigrant parents. Modeling this activity for practitioners required neither a conversion experience on their part nor complex transmutation of “knowledge” into “action” on my part. Once we overcome the metaphysical and evaluative commitments that lead us to divorce theory from practice, anthropologists can more readily find opportunities to change the world by moving ideas, habits and capacities from one domain to another.

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